

Guns or Gandhi: Ethnic Elite Composition and Dissident Tactics in Civil Conflicts

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Abstract

This paper is very cool blbablablab

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Introduction

Violent and Non-violent Campaign Choice

Previous literature has established that civil resistance campaigns and violent campaigns are often a strategic choice made before the campaign (Schock 2005; **Cunninghametal2017?**). One strand of this literature emphasizes the role of political opportunities in shaping these choices (). Campaign leaders evaluate the political environment and assess the likely consequences of alternative tactics, including the prospects for mobilization, repression, elite defections, and policy concessions. The underlying assumption is that dissident organizations are more likely to adopt the tactic they expect to offer the greatest probability of achieving their political objectives. The following paragraphs summarize key political opportunities that shape the relative attractiveness of nonviolent and violent resistance.

A nonviolent campaign is a large-scale collective effort that uses nonviolent methods to achieve major political goal. Such goals may include overthrowing an incumbent government or achieving territorial secession. Common tactics include strikes, boycotts, and sit-ins.

Nonviolent campaigns rely on broad participation and cooperation from large segments of society. Their effectiveness therefore depends on their ability to mobilize supporters, disrupt normal political activity and weaken the regime's sources of support.

As nonviolent resistance depends on mass participation, repression can substantially reduce its effectiveness. Arrests, violence, and intimidation increase the costs of participation and may discourage potential supporters from joining collective action (). Repression can also disrupt organizational networks by targeting leaders and activists who coordinate protest

activities ().

[Paper] showed that a key mechanism through which nonviolent campaigns succeed is by inducing defections among regime supporters. When political elites, bureaucrats, or members of the security forces withdraw their support from the incumbent government, the regime's capacity to govern and repress dissent is weakened ().

In addition to limiting repression, regimes may choose to negotiate or make concessions in response to nonviolent mobilization. When dissidents expect that peaceful collective action can generate meaningful concessions, the expected benefits of nonviolent tactics increase relative to violent alternatives.

Nonviolent resistance is therefore most attractive when dissidents expect high levels of participation, a substantial likelihood of elite or security-force defections, limited repression, and a reasonable prospect of political concessions.

Violent campaigns involve the use of armed force or coercive violence to achieve large political objectives. Unlike nonviolent campaigns, violent resistance does not depend on broad participation in the same way and can be sustained by smaller, more centralized organizations.

Because violent campaigns do not rely on mass mobilization, they may become relatively more attractive when conditions make large-scale participation in nonviolent resistance difficult. In particular, severe repression can raise the costs of open collective action, reducing the feasibility of sustained nonviolent mobilization.

Violent resistance may also be more likely when opportunities for elite or security-force defection are limited. When regimes maintain cohesive ruling coalitions and reliable coercive institutions, nonviolent campaigns are less able to generate the defections that often undermine incumbent governments.

Consequently, political environments characterized by strong elite cohesion, effective repression, and low prospects for defection tend to increase the relative attractiveness of violent forms of resistance.

Ethnic Composition and Campaign Tactic

Political opportunities play a central role in shaping whether dissident campaigns adopt violent or nonviolent strategies. Campaigns evaluate their prospects of success based on expectations about elite defections, repression, and political concessions, and choose the tactic that appears most likely to achieve their objectives.

This study argues that variation in these political opportunities is structured by the ethnic composition of ruling elites. Ethnic fragmentation shapes elite cohesion and thereby influences the likelihood of defection, the effectiveness of repression, and the probability of concessions.

Ethnically heterogeneous ruling coalitions are more vulnerable to elite defection because political loyalty is often embedded in ethnic networks that provide alternative bases of support outside the regime. This increases the likelihood that elites withdraw support under conditions of sustained mobilization.

Ethnic divisions can also weaken coercive capacity by generating coordination problems within security forces and governing institutions, reducing the state's ability to carry out sustained repression.

In addition, fragmented ruling coalitions may be more likely to pursue negotiated settlements, as internal divisions increase the risks associated with prolonged conflict and make concessions a more attractive option for regime survival.

Taken together, ethnic fragmentation increases the likelihood of elite defections, weakens repression, and increases the probability of concessions. These conditions make nonviolent resistance more effective relative to violent forms of contention.

Accordingly, we expect that dissident campaigns facing more ethnically fragmented ruling coalitions will be more likely to adopt nonviolent tactics.

Hypothesis 1. *Greater ethnic fragmentation in ruling elites increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics rather than violent tactics.*

Variation in political opportunities may also arise from differences in the distribution of power among ethnic groups within ruling coalitions. More equally powerful groups possess greater autonomy and capacity to defect, making elite cohesion weaker than in systems dominated by a single group.

Greater equality in the distribution of power among ethnic groups therefore increases the likelihood of elite defection and reduces the effectiveness of repression.

From this mechanism, I derive a second hypothesis:

Hypothesis 2. *Greater equality in the distribution of power among ethnic groups in the ruling elite increases the likelihood that dissident campaigns adopt nonviolent tactics.*

Data and Methods

Data description

Our study employs a panel dataset of 341 so-called “maximalist campaigns”, a concept first introduced by Chenoweth and Stephan in *Why Civil Resistance Works* book (Chenoweth and

Stephan 2011). Following their definition, a campaign is “a series of observable, continuous, purposive mass tactics or events in pursuit of a political objective”, with maximalist objectives encompassing regime change, self-determination, secession, and the expulsion of foreign occupations (Chenoweth and Shay 2019). We rely on Nonviolent and Violent Campaigns and Outcomes (NAVCO) 2.1 dataset, which records 384 maximalist campaigns from 1945 to 2013¹.

The central conceptual distinction is between violent and nonviolent repertoires of contention. Following NAVCO coding rules, nonviolent tactics ‘do not directly threaten or harm the physical wellbeing of the regime, its agents, or its citizens’ and the violent repertoire ‘involves the use of force to physically harm or threaten to harm the opponents’ (Chenoweth and Shay 2019). The categories are mutually exclusive. A prominent example of a nonviolent campaign is the German 1989 *Die Wende* and the Cuban Revolution exemplifies a violent campaign. The violence/nonviolence distinction is well-established in the peace science literature and some significant findings have been made using NAVCO dataset (Celestino and Gleditsch 2013; Manekin and Mitts 2022; Cunningham 2013). Violence is operationally coded as a binary variable (1 = a campaign takes a violent form, 0 = a campaign takes a nonviolent form).

Our key independent variables are drawn from the Ethnic Power Relations (EPR) Core

¹The most significant reason why the number of campaigns we have in the panel dataset differs from the total number of maximalist campaigns concerns country coding. We construct a panel dataset of independent country-years based on Correlates of War (CoW) list of independent states. We merge our panel data using NAVCO-assigned CoW country codes. However, in some cases, countries of a campaign location are not independent at the campaign onset year and thus lost from the data we use in the analysis. For example, there is a campaign geographically located in Algeria in 1952, though Algeria gained independence only in 1962. A naive solution would be assigning socio-economic characteristics of the “target” country - France in case of Algeria, though it would severely bias the results as if the campaign took place in France. We partly address this issue by excluding territorial campaigns in the robustness check section. Table A1 in Appendix C lists all these lost campaigns.

Dataset (Vogt et al. 2015). EPR provides information on ethnic groups and their relative access to power. Following Hendrix and Salehyan (2019), we operationalize the ethnic ruling elite fragmentation via the *Included fractionalization index (IFI)* and the *Excluded fractionalization index (EFI)*. IFI is “a Herfindahl-like index of all groups counted as ‘included’ (i.e. having access to executive power) during a given country-year”, whilst EFI is “a Herfindahl-like index of all groups counted as ‘excluded’ during a given country-year”. Thus, a higher IFI indicates a more concentrated ethnic ruling elite and a lower IFI shows that ethnic power is distributed more equally, across many groups. Instead of relying on raw counts, IFI and EFI are more theoretically motivated. If a raw count treats two countries with the ethnic groups in power count of, say, 3 equally, IFI and EFI account for ethnic power distributions.

Another important source of data is the Ethnic Groups in Contention (EGC), a dataset first introduced by Thurber in 2018 (Thurber 2018). It links NAVCO to EPR and provides additional information on ethnic groups that participated in maximalist campaigns. In a 2026 article, the EGC dataset was updated for NAVCO 2.1, allowing us to use the newest version for our research question (Bivens and Thurber 2026). What we are interested in is whether any ethnic group in power in a specific country participated in the maximalist campaign. Obviously, ethnic groups that are systematically discriminated could mobilize against the ruling regime given their ethnic (and possibly other) grievances, though empowered ethnic groups could also participate in the campaign, supporting the excluded masses - a potential source of significant confounding. Even though such scenarios sound unrealistic, there are 201 where at least one ethnic group in power participated in the campaign. However, in only 36 did such participating ethnic groups in power made an ethnic claim, displaying rather an opportunistic behavior in anticipation of the maximalist campaign success than a sincere will

to express ethnic grievances.

To address endogeneity and block non-causal paths, we control for a standard set of confounders: GDP per capita in constant PPP dollars (Gapminder 2024); logged population size (Nations 2024); executive corruption scores and polyarchy (electoral democracy) scores (Coppedge et al. 2024); regime duration in years (Coppedge et al. 2024); peace years (years elapsed since the last maximalist campaign in each country); EFI to account for a possible confounding of excluded ethnic groups as well; we also control whether at least one ethnic group in power participated in the campaign with a binary variable. To address reversed causality, all the independent variables are one-year lagged².

Descriptive statistics

Table 1: Ethnic and political attributes of NAVCO 2.1 campaign onsets

	Nonviolent (N=156)		Violent (N=185)	
	Mean	Std. Dev.	Mean	Std. Dev.
Included Fractionalization Index	0.401	0.319	0.294	0.293
Excluded Fractionalization Index	0.051	0.115	0.080	0.157
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	0.083	0.277	0.092	0.290
ln(GDP per capita)	8.658	0.894	7.982	0.937
ln(Population)	9.754	1.691	9.807	1.571
Polyarchy	0.297	0.184	0.264	0.173
Executive Corruption	0.607	0.244	0.631	0.249
ln(Regime Duration)	2.246	1.248	1.718	1.249
Peace Years	15.455	14.896	9.787	10.959

Note: All variables one-year lagged.

Table 1 presents descriptive statistics for all variables included in the analysis between nonviolent and violent campaigns. The table shows a balance between violence and nonviolence

²Even though we find it unconvincing that a choice of one tactic over the other could affect IFI and EFI

instances. Nonviolent campaigns have a slightly higher mean Included Fractionalization Index value, while violent campaigns face a slightly higher mean Excluded Fractionalization Index value. For control variables, such as GDP and polyarchy, the table shows some degree of variation between violent and nonviolent campaigns. In general, data missingness is not a significant issue, though there is missing data on ethnic groups for all campaigns in countries where data collection is complicated and ethnic lines are profound, such as Yemen and Somalia³. Figure 1 shows the distribution of the included fractionalization index with respect to the tactic choice, visualized by both a histogram and a density plot. At low IFI values, violent tactics are more frequent and with the growing IFI the nonviolent tactic is prevalent. However, with the growing IFI both tactic choices occur less frequently, reflecting the mass anti-regime mobilization logic - with the growing elite cohesion, political opportunities of rebellion are decreasing, regardless of the repertoire of contention. This visualization shows some degree of variation of 1) the Included Fractionalization Index 2) between violent and nonviolent choice.

Modeling approach

Given a binary dependent variable and a balanced sample -185 of violent and 156 of nonviolent onsets - we estimate a logit model. As we do not predict the duration of events, there is no need for advanced binary choice models such as a complementary log-log. To account for a nested structure of our data, where campaigns are nested within countries, we add a country-level random varying intercept in all models.

Including a country fixed effect to control for the time-invariant unobserved factors

³In general, only 7.33% of IFI values and 7.33% of EFI values are missing

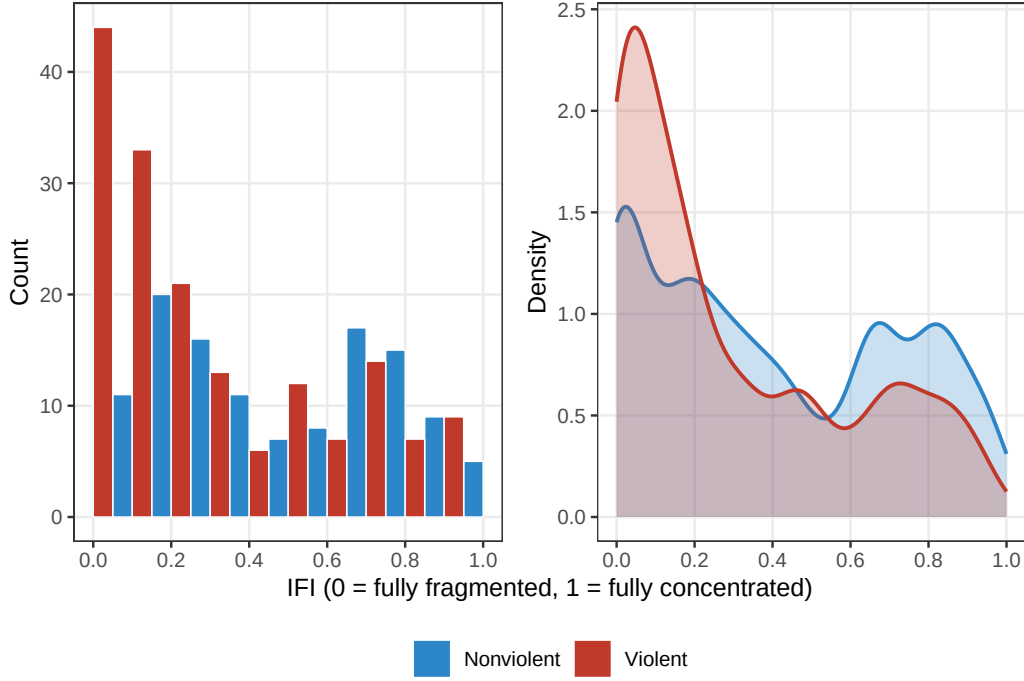


Figure 1: Included fractionalization index by Repertoire Choice: a histogram and a density plot

such as culture or geography is theoretically appealing and common in the peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016; Ives and Breslawski 2022; Fearon and Laitin 2003; Jung 2025). However, given that ethnic structures are almost constant *within* countries and vary predominantly *between* countries - the variation that a country fixed effect absorbs, adding it is methodologically inappropriate. Exploratory data analysis showed that the median within-country standard deviation of both IFI and EFI rounds to 0.01 (up to two decimal points without rounding), meaning that the FE identification would test on a very small sample of countries that experienced ethnic configuration changes between maximalist campaigns. Random effects exploit both within- and between-group variations, which is appropriate for our research question and data structure. Moreover, a random-effects estimator introduces “a compromise between the fixed-effects and pooled models”, though we acknowledge that

the coefficients can be partially biased in case varying intercepts correlate with the regressors (Clark and Linzer 2015). Despite this potential bias, RE is still a more preferable choice over FE.

For Hypothesis 1, our model specification is:

$$\text{violent}_{it} \sim \text{Bernoulli}(\pi_{it})$$

$$\log\left(\frac{\pi_{it}}{1 - \pi_{it}}\right) = \beta_0 + \beta_1(\text{IFI})_{it-1} + \beta_2(\text{EFI})_{it-1} + \mathbf{X}'_{it-1}\boldsymbol{\gamma} + \alpha_{[j]i}$$

$$\alpha_j \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_\alpha, \sigma_\alpha^2)$$

where $\mathbf{X}_{it-1}$ is the vector of covariates and $\alpha_{[j]i}$ is a country varying intercept.

For uncertainty calculations, we follow a King’s simulation approach (King, Tomz, and Wittenberg 2000). This approach is also well-established in peace science literature (Butcher and Svensson 2016). Instead of reporting coefficients and their significance, we calculate predicted probabilities as the main quantity of interest via an observed value approach (OVA), meaning we simulate the predicted probabilities for all observations and then calculate the mean of them⁴. We simulate over the full available range of the focal variable values. For the essay, we define `sim_ova_range` function for the OVA simulations, allowing to calculate predicted probabilities in just four lines of code. It also allows for different CI levels, seeds, number of values and focal variable ranges at the researcher’s discretion.

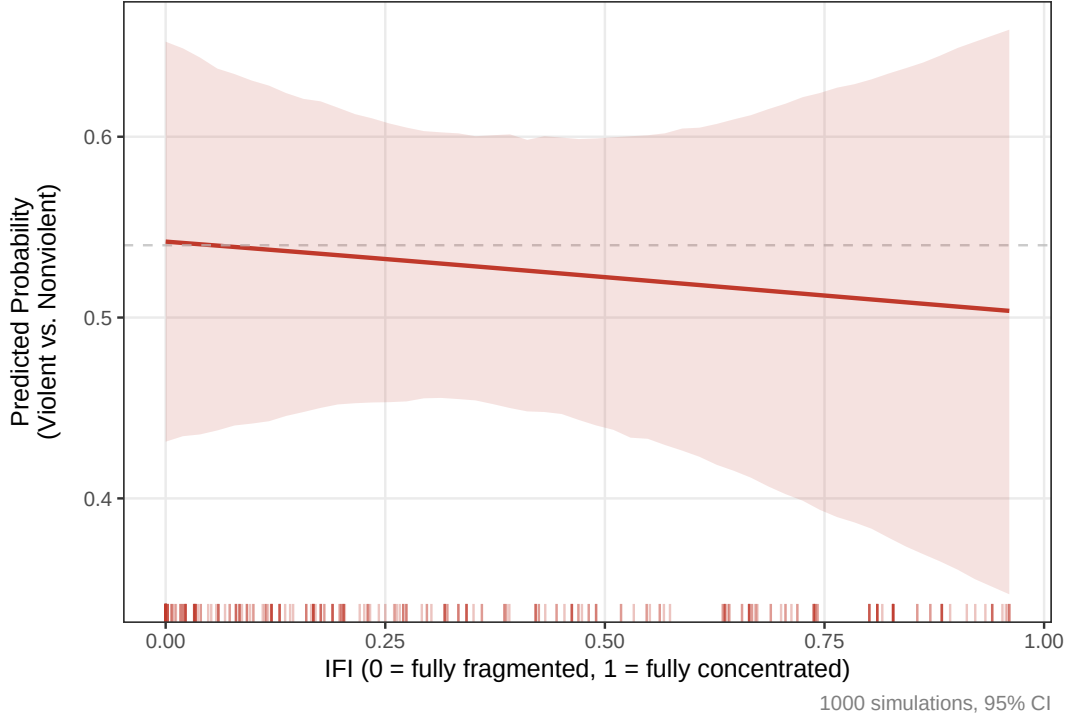


Figure 2: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of included fractionalization index values

Results

To test the first hypothesis, we estimate a logit model of the violent tactic choice, according to the H1 model specification. Figure 2 shows the simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a full available range of observed IFI values. Despite a downward trend - from 0.54 at IFI equal to 0 to 0.5 at IFI equal to 0.96 - confidence intervals that encompass 0.5 do not allow us to claim that with the increasing IFI the rebels would prefer violence over nonviolence. Instead of zero probability, our benchmark probability is approx. 0.54 - the sample proportion of violent campaigns in the whole sample.

Despite an insignificant effect of IFI on a violent choice, the model as a whole demonstrates a strong predictive performance. We divided the dataset into a train and test sample,

⁴We report coefficients only in the cross-validation robustness check

Table 2: Confusion Matrix and Predictive Performance — Model 1

	Actual Nonviolent	Actual Violent
Confusion Matrix		
Predicted Nonviolent	19	18
Predicted Violent	12	29
Performance Metrics		
Accuracy	0.615	
Precision	0.707	
Recall	0.617	
F1 Score	0.659	
AUC	0.721	

estimated a logit model on the train sample and predicted a tactic choice on the test set. Table 2 reports the confusion matrix and performance metrics. With an accuracy of 0.62 and F1 score of 0.66, our model in general predicts tactic choice well above a coin toss, predicting violence a bit better than the nonviolent choice. Another measure of model fit is the area under the ROC curve (AUC), showing whether our model predictions of a violent choice are better than a random draw. The AUC score of 0.72 indicates a good model fit. Figure A1 plots an AUC-ROC curve for this model. An important implication here is that the model as a whole (including the specification itself, a set of covariates and a country varying intercept) captures meaningful variation in the outcome, even though the IFI does not significantly predict a violent choice. Such results reflect a real absence of the IFI effect rather than a model misspecification.

Robustness checks

We conduct four robustness checks. First, given that civil conflicts and a tactic choice are regionally clustered, we estimate an additional model on the Middle East and North Africa

(MENA) and Sub-Saharan Africa countries subsample, where violent campaigns are more expected than in other regions. For the full sample, there are 54.3% of violent campaigns, whilst for MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa there are 65.5% of them. Second, territorial campaigns could be more ethnicity-driven and secessionist civil wars along ethnic lines are widely researched in the academic literature (Collier and Hoeffler 2006; Denny and Walter 2014; Toft 2012). For this reason, we estimated three separate models 1) on the MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa subsample, 2) excluding territorial campaigns and 3) both on the MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa sub-sample with excluded territorial campaigns. Finally, following Bell and Jones (2015), we estimate an alternative Within-Between Random Effect (REWB) model specification. REWB presents a main independent variable in two forms: its demeaned form and a group mean. De-meaning allows to estimate a *within* (essentially fixed) effect and save the underlying assumption of the varying intercept model. An important note here is that we do not compare the model fit of these specifications because of the different samples, which make the models incomparable in terms of model fit measures.

We calculate simulated predicted probabilities over the full available range of IFI values for all three robustness check models and summarize the findings on one plot. Figure 3 shows the results along three robustness specifications, including the full-sample baseline. The only partially significant finding is in the model which excludes territorial campaigns (this sub-sample mostly includes anti-regime campaigns). For low IFI values, campaigns that exclude territorial goals/claims have a higher chance of being nonviolent and the rebels slowly push towards a higher likelihood of violence with the growing IFI value. This (though cautious) finding can be explained by the logic of mass anti-regime mobilization, where a more concentrated ethnic elite decreases the benefits of nonviolent resistance and pushes

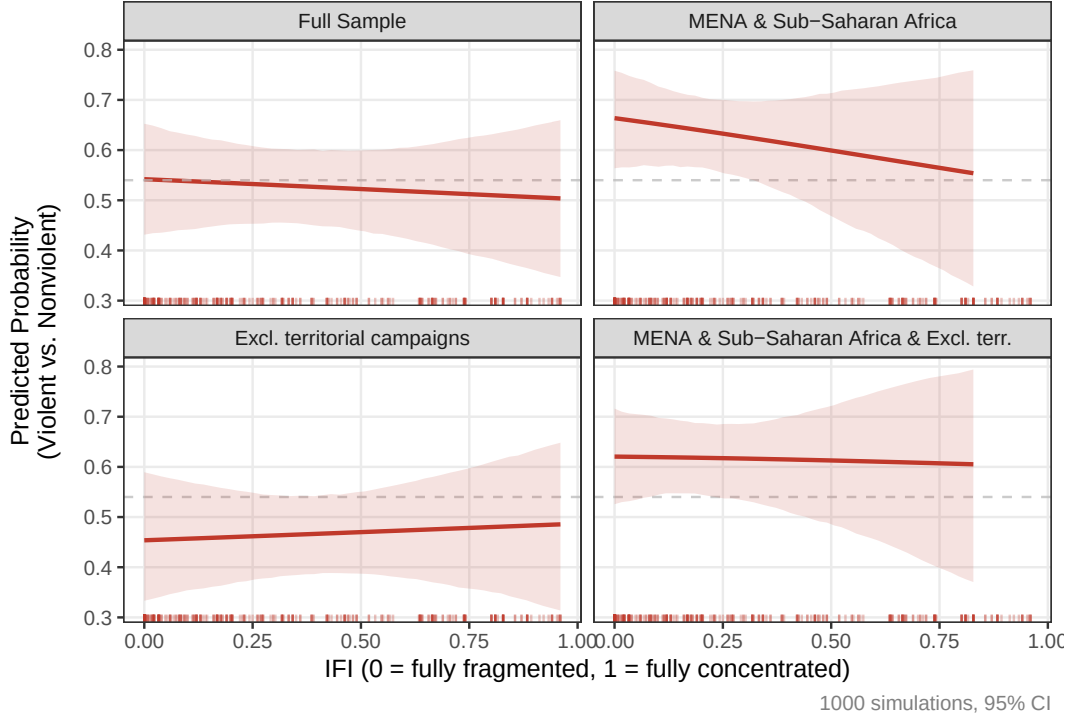


Figure 3: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of IFI values - robustness checks results

the rebels toward violent repertoires of contention. For the MENA & Sub-Saharan Africa subsample (both with and without territorial campaigns) there is no systematic difference between violence and nonviolence across the growing IFI value. Figure A2 plots simulated predicted probabilities for the baseline and the REWB model, demonstrating practically identical results (see Appendix A). In general, our null result is robust⁵.

Finally, we cross-validate the results (5 cross-validations) to check whether the same results hold when models are estimated on different random subsamples. For this, we define the `cross_validation_fun` function⁶. For this part, we did not calculate quantities of interest,

⁵We do not calculate performance metrics for the robustness check specifications due to identification issues and low sample sizes, caused by simultaneous regional/campaign type and train-test subsampling.

⁶Cross-validation subsampling causes convergence issues due to low sample sizes of the subsamples. To address this, we force the function to resample and reestimate the model until convergence. Thus, it can take more than one attempt to estimate one cross-validated subsample. It took 8 attempts to estimate 5 cross-validations

Table 3: Model 1: Main vs. Cross-Validated Coefficients

Variable	Main Model	Cross-Validated
IFI	-0.180 (0.669)	-0.379 (0.381)
EFI	1.394 (1.488)	2.772 (2.594)
Ethnic Group in Power Participation	-0.077 (0.500)	0.048 (0.494)
ln(GDP per capita)	-0.816 (0.208)	-0.832 (0.189)
ln(Population)	-0.074 (0.128)	-0.084 (0.107)
Polyarchy	0.504 (0.951)	0.579 (0.892)
Executive Corruption	0.104 (0.717)	0.215 (0.676)
ln(Regime Duration)	-0.261 (0.133)	-0.249 (0.184)
Peace Years	-0.021 (0.014)	-0.024 (0.012)

Note: Intercept is not reported. Standard errors in parentheses. Cross-validated SE via King (2001) combination rule.

but rather compare coefficient values and their significance, which will be enough to judge whether the results are stable or not. Table 3 shows the coefficients differences between the main and the cross-validated model. For both models, the IFI coefficient is negative and insignificant, though the coefficient absolute values differ. Moreover, one could notice a slight inflation of the standard errors, though not significantly changing the null result. Moreover, the reader should account for the sample size and respective test sample sizes that partly explain standard errors' inflation.

Discussion

Conclusion

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Appendix

Appendix A: AUC - ROC Curve

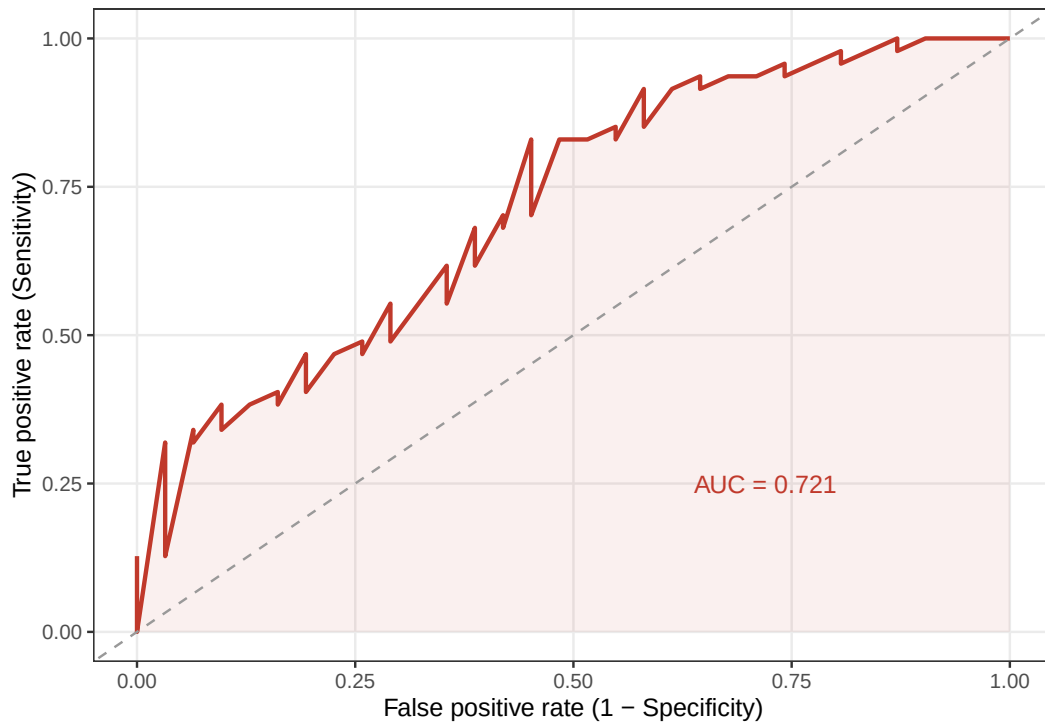


Figure A1: AUC-ROC Curve - Model 1

Appendix B: Within-Between Random Effects Robustness Check

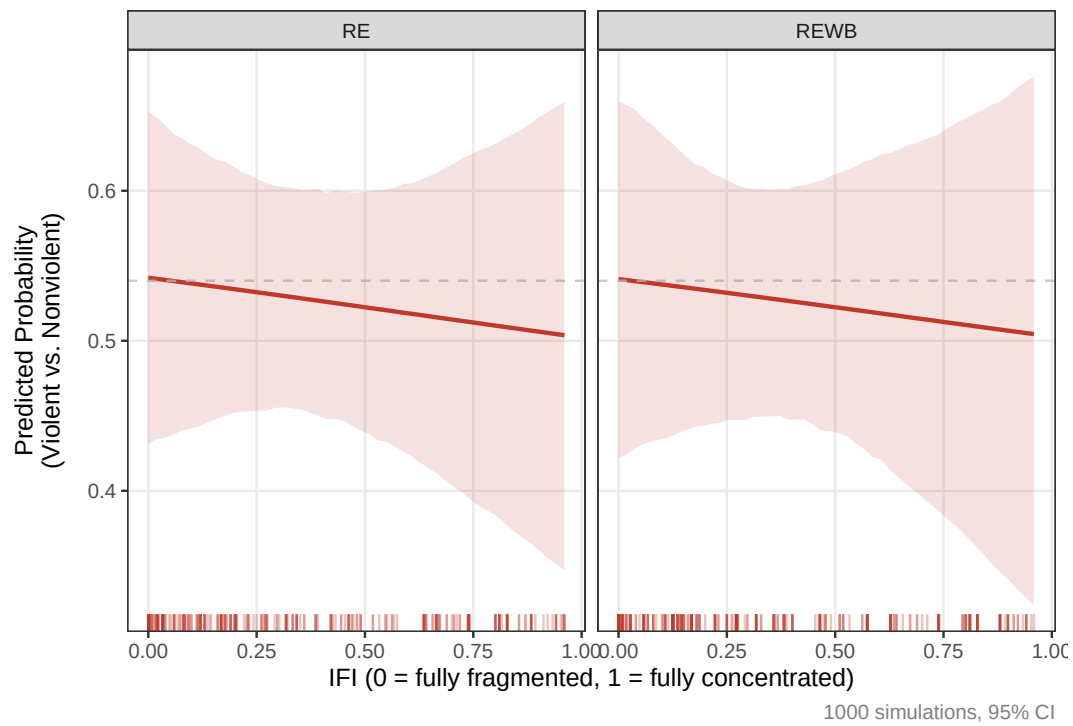


Figure A2: Simulated predicted probabilities of a violent tactic choice over a range of IFI values - baseline vs. REWB

Appendix C: Campaigns excluded from the empirical analysis due to country coding issues

Table A1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample due to states panel coverage

COW code	Year	Country
615	1952	Algeria
540	1961	Angola
370	1988	Belarus
346	1991	Bosnia & Herzegovina
835	1962	Brunei
811	1946	Cambodia
471	1955	Cameroon
344	1991	Croatia
352	1954	Cyprus
315	1967	Czechoslovakia
315	1989	Czechoslovakia
531	1945	Eritrea
366	1945	Estonia
366	1987	Estonia
265	1953	German Democratic Republic

Table A1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample
due to states panel coverage (*continued*)

COW code	Year	Country
452	1948	Ghana
404	1963	Guinea-Bissau
750	1946	India
850	1945	Indonesia
501	1952	Kenya
703	1990	Kyrgyzstan
812	1946	Laos
812	1950	Laos
367	1945	Latvia
367	1989	Latvia
368	1945	Lithuania
368	1988	Lithuania
580	1947	Madagascar
553	1958	Malawi
820	1948	Malaysia
600	1953	Morocco
541	1963	Mozambique

Table A1: Campaigns excluded from the analysis sample
due to states panel coverage (*continued*)

COW code	Year	Country
565	1960	Namibia
475	1945	Nigeria
698	1964	Oman
517	1956	Rwanda
517	1961	Rwanda
317	1989	Slovakia
349	1991	Slovenia
713	1947	Taiwan
860	1975	Timor-Leste
616	1952	Tunisia
369	1990	Ukraine
816	1945	Vietnam
679	1948	Yemen
679	1955	Yemen
679	1960	Yemen

Note: N = 48 campaigns. For the reasons of exclusion: see a footnote in the introduction